frameworks.[31] Therefore, ‘development’ warrants a brief unpacking to understand its impact on indigeneity.[32]

While the 2007 Declaration is said to be the most comprehensive document on indigenous rights, it in itself treats ‘development’ as the universal set in which the indigenous way of life is but a subset, an island, a safe space carved out, thereby tragically failing to understand the very concept of indigeneity and address the coloniality underlying contemporary notions of development. Not only is development laced with modernity as defined by the West, the manner in which such development must be pursued and attained is also dictated by the West ever since the grant of ‘development aid’ was made contingent on reshaping ‘independent’ former colonies in the mould of the West. As a result, the pursuit of such yardsticks of development has been adopted as the national goal of several former colonies. All aspects of life—from laws to ‘religion’ to the production of knowledge and education—have been reoriented towards the achievement of Western-style development. Therefore, until ‘development’ is itself subjected to a decolonial filter, it will single-handedly propel indigenous peoples towards a Westernised future because it first and foremost affects a community’s relationship with nature, which percolates right down to the individual. Clearly, at the heart of it, the tussle is between colonial perception of humankind’s centrality to nature on the one hand and its actual place within nature on the other, which informs indigeneity, and hence decoloniality.

Coming to decolonial scholarship on ‘indigeneity’, in contrast to the ILO definitions that are heavily ethnocentric and are subscribed to by the postcolonial school, decoloniality focusses on indigenous consciousness owing to its recognition that the ‘tribal’ identity was invented by the European coloniser to advance the goals of colonialism. Decolonial thought takes a multipronged approach to ‘indigeneity’ by distilling the building blocks that constitute the ‘state of being indigenous’ beyond the superficial plane of ‘identity’.[33] This is also because decolonial thought is aware of the Latin origins of ‘indigenous’, which is derived from the Latin term ‘indigenes’, meaning ‘born in the country’. Such a purely birth-based approach could have the automatic effect of treating even the settler coloniser’s progeny as indigenous, which would be absurd from a consciousness perspective. In any case, assumptions of ethnic purity to